was letting my wife and my family down. The justification, that I was chasing my dreams, was wearing a bit thin.

I was no different from a globetrotting businessman or a foreign correspondent. My job meant I had to spend long periods away from home. I had rationalized that with Alice early on in our relationship. I wasn't the normal, run-of-the-mill boyfriend, not because I was somehow special, but because that was how I made my living.

The one huge change in my life since the Oval has been the birth of our son Jack, who could have caused all sorts of havoc by turning up, as predicted, on the day of that 147. He was less than two hours old when I was given an insight into his future, as the son of a former England captain. 'Has he got his first cricket bat yet?' asked the midwife.

Give him a chance. It might be that he absolutely loves driving tractors, just as Elsie or Isobel might fancy themselves as the new Charlotte Edwards. You never know, do you? That is part of life's beautiful uncertainty. Like all fathers, all I pray for is that they will be healthy and happy. If that involves sport, then great.

There's a cool photograph of me, with Jimmy, on the cover of the 2019 edition of *Wisden* . The skeletal frame of the Oval gas holder is in the background. That'll be something to look back on when we are in our sixties, and our families will be glad to get us out of the house. I don't want to sound like a human fortune cookie, or one of those centenarians who are asked for the secrets of long life when the Queen's telegram arrives, but I can sum up cricket's most important life lesson in four words.

Don't be found wanting.